

Ki Tavo Week Master

12-16 Elul 5786 / 25-29 August 2026

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Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren
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Elul 12: King in the Field

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Elul 12, 5786 / August 25, 2026

The King in the Field and the Architecture of Non-Domination: Covenantal Accountability from Ki Teitzei to Ki Tavo amid Contested Dominion

In the twelfth of Elul 5786 the Jewish people stand between the ethical demands of Parashat Ki Teitzei and the covenantal ratification of Parashat Ki Tavo. The season is defined by the classic Chassidic image of the King in the Field. As the Alter Rebbe teaches in Likkutei Torah (Re'eh), before the King returns to the palace for the Days of Awe He goes out into the field; anyone who desires may approach Him without the formal barriers of court protocol, and the King receives all with a smiling countenance. The Lubavitcher Rebbe repeatedly deepened this mashal: the revelation of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy in Elul does not compel service but enables it; the initiative remains with the human being. Free will is not nullified by Divine nearness; it is empowered by it. Teshuvah becomes possible precisely because the King has made Himself accessible in the ordinary places of life—the field of daily conduct, commerce, and political responsibility.

This accessibility does not abolish hierarchy or law. It reframes them. The King remains King; the subject remains bound by the Torah. What changes is the mode of encounter: the possibility of voluntary approach rather than distant submission. In the language of political theory this maps onto the distinction between domination and non-domination.

Philip Pettit's neo-republican account of freedom as non-domination holds that a person is free when no other agent possesses the capacity to interfere arbitrarily in his or her choices. Interference may still occur, but it must be forced to track the interests and ideas of those subject to it; it cannot rest on the mere will (arbitrium) of the powerful. Domination exists whenever one party holds unchecked power of interference, even if that power is temporarily unused. Classical republicanism, from Roman sources through early modern theorists, sought institutional architectures—mixed constitution, contestatory citizenship, rule of law—that would secure non-domination without the state itself becoming a new dominus.

Yoram Hazony's biblical particularism supplies a complementary and corrective register. Drawing on the Hebrew Bible's vision of limited nations living under their own laws within assigned borders (Deuteronomy 2), Hazony argues that the political form most consistent with human flourishing is the independent nation-state rooted in

shared history, language, and covenantal memory rather than imperial universalism. Empire seeks to erase particularity under a single doctrine; biblical nationalism affirms the dignity of peoples who govern themselves under higher law without seeking to dominate others.

Daniel Elazar's covenantal federalism further clarifies the architecture. Biblical brit is neither pure contract nor pure status; it is a morally binding relationship that creates mutual obligation under a transcendent standard. Federal arrangements distribute power so that no single center can dominate the whole, while the covenant itself remains the ultimate check.

Within Orthodox thought these themes find precise expression in the laws of kingship. Rambam (Hilchot Melachim 1–4) codifies that Israel is commanded to appoint a king, yet the king is rigorously limited: he may not multiply horses, wives, or silver and gold; he must write a Torah scroll and keep it with him; his heart must not be lifted above his brothers. The purpose of the monarchy is to execute justice and wage the wars of God, not to accumulate arbitrary power. The king who rules according to Torah is legitimate; the king who seeks to stand above the Torah becomes a source of domination. Parallel discussions in the Rishonim (Ramban, Abarbanel) debate whether monarchy is ideal or concession, yet all agree that unlimited kingship is foreign to the Torah's vision.

Elul therefore offers a double movement. The King in the Field makes Himself available so that free agents may approach in teshuvah; the same King, through the Torah, forbids any human authority from claiming unchecked dominion. Teshuvah itself is the exercise of free will under Divine accessibility: the recognition that one's prior choices have created distance, and the decision to close that distance while the opportunity remains open.

These principles illuminate the present geopolitical field. The Strait of Hormuz has become a theater of contested dominion. Iranian strategy has sought to convert geographic position into the capacity for arbitrary interference—tolls, selective passage, threats of closure—precisely the definition of domination. Claims of sovereignty over an international waterway critical to global energy flows assert a power that need not track the legitimate interests of other nations or commercial actors. American and allied responses, however imperfectly executed, aim at restoring conditions in which transit is not subject to the unilateral will of a single regional actor. From a covenantal-republican perspective the normative question is clear: no power may hold the capacity to dominate the common spaces upon which free peoples depend.

Domestically, Israeli electoral politics approaching the October 2026 elections raise

parallel questions of accountability. High-stakes contests between established leadership and alternative centers of gravity test whether institutions remain responsive to the citizenry or drift toward insulated power. Covenantal republicanism insists that electoral mechanisms, like the limited kingship of Deuteronomy 17, must remain subordinate to higher law and open to contestation. Turnout, coalition formation, and the willingness of leaders to accept the judgment of the people are practical tests of non-domination. When authority forgets that it is held under the Torah and the covenant of the people, it begins to resemble the arbitrary power the tradition rejects.

Ki Teitzei supplies the ethical texture: honest weights and measures, protection of the vulnerable, memory of Amalek as the archetype of those who prey on the weak and the stragglers. Ki Tavo moves from ethics to formal covenant: the people declare, and are declared, a treasured nation under the terms of the Torah. The sequence is not accidental. Ethical integrity in the ordinary field of life prepares the ground for public covenantal affirmation. In Elul the two movements converge: personal teshuvah in the presence of the accessible King, and collective recommitment to an order that refuses domination—whether foreign or domestic, economic or political.

Different streams within Orthodoxy emphasize different accents. Some stress the mystical accessibility of Elul and the transformative power of simple approach; others underline the juridical limits on power and the necessity of rigorous halakhic accountability. Within republican theory, neo-Roman institutionalists and more particularist or Hebraic thinkers debate the relative weight of formal constitutional design versus shared national memory and covenantal ethos. The Torah functions as the foundational and corrective framework: it affirms the value of limited, accountable authority while insisting that ultimate sovereignty belongs to Heaven. Human institutions are instruments for the realization of justice under that sovereignty, never its replacement.

The practical implication for this season is straightforward. While the King is in the field, free agents—citizens, leaders, nations—are invited to approach, to examine the weights and measures of their public life, and to restore architectures of non-domination. Hormuz must not become a private fief. Electoral power must remain answerable. Personal conduct must reflect the honest scales of Ki Teitzei. Only then does the covenantal declaration of Ki Tavo become more than words; it becomes the lived structure of a people who refuse both the slavery of domination and the illusion of unbounded autonomy.

The opportunity of Elul is not indefinite. The King will return to the palace. The field will again become ordinary. Those who meet Him now, while access is open and initiative

is still required, prepare themselves—and their polities—for the judgment and the renewal that follow.

Extended Bibliography (selected, with hyperlinks where available)

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Ki Tavo: Permanent Architecture

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12 Elul 5786 / 25 August 2026

Parashat Ki Tavo season

The Permanent Architecture of the Jewish State: Sovereignty, Limited Power, and Civic Virtue under Covenant

Israel's political life is not a succession of campaigns. It is the continuous effort of a particular people, restored to its ancestral land under the pressure of history and the claims of Torah, to maintain institutions that embody both national particularism and republican non-domination. The architecture is permanent. Coalitions, elections, and legislative episodes rearrange the furniture; they do not alter the load-bearing walls.

Structural Reality

Israel remains a unicameral parliamentary republic without a single entrenched constitution. Sovereignty is exercised through a Knesset elected by nationwide closed-list proportional representation (3.25 percent threshold), an executive formed by coalition bargaining, a judiciary whose authority rests on Basic Laws that can themselves be amended by ordinary majorities, and an IDF that continues to command the highest levels of public trust while the elected institutions languish near historic lows. These are settled features, not temporary accidents.

The completion of a full four-year term by the 25th Knesset demonstrated that coalition discipline can produce formal stability. Discipline, however, is not cohesion. Discipline can hold a government; only organic solidarity can sustain a republic across generations. The subsequent legislative activity—amendments to the composition of the Judicial Selection Committee scheduled to take effect in the next Knesset, efforts to redefine the binding force of the Attorney General's opinions, and the passage of Basic Law: Torah Study—illuminates the permanent tension rather than resolving it. In the absence of a rigid constitution, every major institutional question remains open to ordinary majoritarian revision. That openness is both a republican strength (popular sovereignty) and a standing vulnerability (the risk of temporary majorities rewriting the rules of the game).

Public trust data remain structural signals. Among Jews the IDF consistently ranks first (recent measurements in the mid-to-high 70s to low 80s percent). Trust in the Knesset

and government remains in the teens to low twenties. When the instrument of force outranks the instruments of consent by such a margin, the republican quality of the polity is under measurable strain. Civic virtue—the willingness of free citizens to appear, deliberate, and accept reciprocal burdens—becomes the variable that formal architecture alone cannot supply.

Torah Ideal and Political Practice

Parashat Ki Tavo opens with the farmer who brings first fruits and recites the national story: "My father was a fugitive Aramean..." The private harvest is subordinated to the collective narrative of redemption and inheritance. The ceremony is public acknowledgment that land and people stand under covenant. The same parasha later sets the blessings and curses, the public reading of the Torah, and the solemn "today" on which the people become a nation bound to the commandments. Free will is presupposed; accountability is inescapable.

The classical model of limited kingship supplies the complementary constraint. The Rambam in Hilchot Melachim insists that the king exists to execute justice and to wage the wars of God, not to aggrandize himself. Even the expansive powers of I Samuel 8 are bounded by purpose. Discretionary war requires the concurrence of the Great Court. The ideal is not the absence of authority but authority directed toward the elevation of Torah and the protection of the people, under higher law. Modern Israeli institutions inherit neither anointed kingship nor Sanhedrin, yet the principle remains operative: power that escapes accountability to the people's enduring covenantal standards risks becoming domination rather than service.

Covenantal republicanism therefore rejects both pure majoritarianism and pure juristocracy. It insists that the people remain the ultimate earthly source of legitimacy while remaining themselves under the higher law that defines the character of the Jewish state. Particularist national responsibility is not optional; neither is the non-domination of free citizens by arbitrary power—whether exercised by a transient coalition, an entrenched bureaucracy, an unaccountable court, or a sectoral veto elevated into permanent exemption from reciprocal obligation.

The recent Basic Law: Torah Study and the unresolved burden-sharing question around military service function as structural windows. Torah study is indeed a fundamental value of the Jewish people. When that value is translated into a permanent sectoral exemption from the shared defense burden that sustains the state's physical existence, the covenantal principle of mutual obligation is strained. Reciprocal burden-sharing is not a left-wing or right-wing demand; it is a republican and covenantal requirement. Honest weights apply to public life as they apply to the

market.

Competing Approaches and the Covenantal Standard

Several durable approaches continue to compete for the soul of Israeli politics.

Pure realism treats power and security as the sole measures of success and regards institutional form as secondary. It correctly prioritizes survival yet underestimates the long-term cost of eroded civic legitimacy and the refusal of reciprocal burdens.

Liberal institutionalism elevates universal individual rights and procedural checks as the primary goods, often treating Jewish particularism as a problem to be managed rather than a foundational premise. It strengthens certain constraints on power while frequently weakening the national covenant that alone justifies the state's existence in this land.

Theocratic maximalism seeks to translate halakhic categories directly into state law without the mediating republican forms of consent, representation, and limited authority. It risks collapsing the distinction between divine law and human political judgment and can produce new forms of domination under religious color.

Quietism and certain strands of progressive universalism both tend to evacuate particular national responsibility—the former by withdrawal, the latter by dissolving the Jewish character of the state into a neutral procedural democracy. Both leave the field to those who organize while others disengage.

The covenantal-republican standard evaluates each by three tests:

Does it protect Jewish sovereignty as the concrete expression of national particularism?

Does it constrain power so that no agent can dominate arbitrarily?

Does it cultivate the civic virtue required for free citizens to appear and to accept mutual obligation?

Approaches that fail these tests, whatever their short-term tactical advantages, erode the permanent architecture.

Long-Term Resilience

Resilience is not the mere survival of formal institutions. It is the capacity of the polity to renew the organic solidarity that makes formal institutions legitimate. High-quality political participation—turnout understood as covenantal appearance rather than private preference—belongs to that resilience. Honest weights in public life, equitable sharing of the defense burden, and the refusal to allow sectoral vetoes to harden into

permanent domination belong to it as well.

The full-term completion of a Knesset is a modest institutional achievement. The deeper achievement will be the restoration of a civic culture in which citizens treat the polity as a shared inheritance rather than a temporary arena for factional gain. Elul is the season of heshbon ha-nefesh. The national heshbon remains structural: Will the architecture of the Jewish state continue to house a free people under covenant, or will it slowly become the arena of those who organize while others withdraw?

The Pittsburgh experience of industrial mutual reliance and the Jerusalem experience of living under the ancient walls teach the same lesson in different registers: communities endure when members show up for one another under pressure and refuse to outsource responsibility. The Jewish state is no exception. Its permanent architecture will hold only if the people continue to appear as a people under covenant.

All ultimate credit and glory belong to the Ribono shel Olam alone. The State is a miraculous keili; it is never the Source.

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

Jerusalem – Outpost of Steelers Nation

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI.

Extended Bibliography (with hyperlinks)

Classical Jewish Sources

- Devarim 26–29 (Ki Tavo – first fruits, covenant declaration, blessings and curses): <https://www.sefaria.org/Deuteronomy.26>
- Rambam, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Melachim uMilchamot: https://www.chabad.org/library/article_cdo/aid/1188341/jewish/Melachim-uMilchamot.htm
- Rambam on the purpose of kingship and constraints: https://www.sefaria.org/Mishneh_Torah%2C_Kings_and_Wars

Republican Political Theory

- Philip Pettit, *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government* (Oxford, 1997) – non-domination as absence of arbitrary interference.
- Daniel J. Elazar, *Covenant and Polity in Biblical Israel and the Covenant Tradition* series.
- Yoram Hazony, *The Virtue of Nationalism* (Basic Books, 2018).
- Joshua Berman, *Created Equal: How the Bible Broke with Ancient Political Thought* (Oxford, 2008).

Israeli Institutions & Structural Analysis

- Israel Democracy Institute, Israeli Democracy Index 2025 (trust rankings, institutional assessments): <https://en.idi.org.il/articles/62722>
- Public trust series (IDF consistently highest among Jews; Knesset and government persistently low): recent IDI and related polling 2025–early 2026.
- Basic Laws of Israel and ongoing structural literature on the absence of a rigid constitution, Judicial Selection Committee composition, and the status of the Attorney General.
- Analyses of proportional representation, coalition dynamics, and reciprocal burden-sharing as permanent features of the Israeli system.

Prior Corpus Continuity

- Type 1 Master Permanent Architecture, 10 Elul 5786.
- Earlier reflections on parliamentary cohesion versus organic solidarity, limited power, civic virtue, and the quality of turnout as covenantal participation in the Jewish state.

Ki Tavo Elul non-domination

Source: <https://grok.com/chat/9412044e-11e5-4e5c-9e64-a8d1a2ab5e2d>

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Covenantal Accountability in the Field: Ki Tavo, Elul, and the Architecture of Non-Domination

In the thirteenth day of Elul 5786 the people of Israel stand again in the open field of the King. The Alter Rebbe's classic parable teaches that in Elul the King leaves the palace and enters the ordinary places where His subjects live and labor. Accessibility is radical; judgment is postponed; free will is maximized. The same month that opens the gates of teshuvah also frames Parashat Ki Tavo, the portion that places the individual Israelite farmer before the altar with a basket of first-fruits and requires him to recite a personal and national history of dependence, gratitude, and covenantal obligation.

The farmer declares: "An Aramean sought to destroy my father... and He brought us to this place and gave us this land, a land flowing with milk and honey. And now, behold, I have brought the first of the fruit of the ground which You, O Lord, have given me" (Devarim 26:5–10). The declaration is not mere liturgy. It is a public renunciation of self-sufficiency and an affirmation that dominion over the land is held under higher law. Immediately thereafter the Torah moves to the dramatic ceremony of blessings and curses on the two mountains, a national acceptance of the covenant whose terms include both flourishing and the terrifying tochacha. Free will is the hinge: "See, I have set before you today life and good, death and evil" is the recurring Deuteronomic refrain that reaches its sharpest expression here.

Rambam, in Hilchot Teshuvah 5 and Hilchot Melachim, insists that free will is the foundation of the entire Torah. Without it, neither reward nor punishment, neither commandment nor repentance, retains meaning. In Hilchot Melachim the ideal king is limited: he writes a Torah scroll for himself, reads it all his days, and is forbidden to multiply horses, wives, or silver and gold beyond measure. Sovereignty is real yet bounded by the higher sovereignty of the divine law. The king who forgets this becomes a tyrant; the people who forget it invite the tochacha.

Chassidic thought deepens the free-will theme. The Rebbe repeatedly returns to the Elul field as the place where the arousal from below meets the arousal from above. Teshuvah is not primarily emotional catharsis but the reassertion of the soul's essential freedom to choose the good. Tanya's language of the two souls and the constant battle within the heart finds its seasonal intensification in Elul: the field is level ground; every Jew, regardless of prior standing, can approach.

Republican political theory supplies a complementary vocabulary. Philip Pettit's conception of freedom as non-domination—freedom not merely as non-interference but as the secure status of not being subject to the arbitrary will of another—resonates with the Torah's rejection of both foreign domination and domestic arbitrary power. Yoram Hazony's recovery of biblical particularism and the nation as a covenantal order, and Daniel Elazar's work on covenantal federalism and the Hebraic sources of republican thought, illuminate the same architecture. Classical republicanism's mixed constitution, its suspicion of concentrated power, and its insistence on civic virtue find an older and deeper articulation in the limited kingship of Shoftim and the personal accountability of Ki Tavo.

Within Orthodoxy, approaches diverge. Some streams emphasize the hierarchical authority of the king or the sage as near-absolute within the bounds of Torah. Others, drawing on the same Rambam and on the historical experience of Jewish self-government, stress the covenantal consent of the governed and the ongoing right—and duty—of the people to hold power accountable. Academic republicanism likewise divides between more civic-humanist readings that privilege virtue and more institutional readings that privilege constitutional design. The Torah prioritizes neither pure institutionalism nor pure charismatic hierarchy; it demands both a Torah-bound institutional order and the free-willed moral agency of persons who must bring their first-fruits and accept the blessings and curses.

Applied to the present moment, the Strait of Hormuz appears as a textbook case of contested dominion. One power seeks to convert geographic choke-point into arbitrary leverage over global energy and commerce; another asserts freedom of navigation under a different conception of order. Non-domination requires that no single will, whether Iranian, American, or any other, hold the capacity to dominate the common channels of the sea. The Torah's suspicion of concentrated power that multiplies horses and chariots (or mines and missiles) without limit supplies a normative critique that secular realism alone cannot generate.

Israeli elections scheduled for 27 October 2026 likewise stand under the sign of covenantal accountability. The people are not subjects of a perpetual government; they are partners in a covenant who periodically reconstitute the limited authority under which they live. High turnout, informed choice, and the rejection of both messianic absolutism and cynical resignation are the political analogues of the farmer's first-fruits declaration and the people's acceptance of the covenant on the two mountains. Elul's King-in-the-Field accessibility reminds every citizen that the window of free choice remains open until the coronation of Rosh Hashanah.

The synthesis is therefore clear. Orthodox Jewish theology supplies the foundational

anthropology of free will, the limited character of human sovereignty, and the seasonal urgency of teshuvah. Republican theory supplies analytic tools for diagnosing domination and designing non-dominating institutions. The Torah remains the corrective framework: any theory of freedom that severs itself from the higher law collapses into either license or new forms of domination. In the open field of Elul, with the first-fruits basket in hand and the mountains of blessing and curse before us, the task is to choose life—personal, national, and geopolitical—under the banner of covenantal non-domination.

Extended Bibliography (selected, with hyperlinks)

- Deuteronomy 26–29 (Sefaria): <https://www.sefaria.org/Deuteronomy.26>
- Rambam, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Teshuvah 5; Hilchot Melachim uMilchamot: https://www.sefaria.org/Mishneh_Torah%2C_Repentance.5 ; https://www.chabad.org/library/article_cdo/aid/1188343/jewish/Melachim-uMilchamot-Chapter-1.htm
- Tanya / Likkutei Amarim and Elul teachings (Chabad.org): https://www.chabad.org/library/tanya/tanya_cdo/aid/1028862/jewish/Chapter-1.htm ; https://www.chabad.org/kabbalah/article_cdo/aid/379688/jewish/With-the-King-in-the-Field.htm
- Philip Pettit, *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government* (Oxford, 1997).
- Yoram Hazony, *The Virtue of Nationalism* (Basic Books, 2018) and related Hebraic political writings.
- Daniel J. Elazar, *Covenant and Polity in Biblical Israel and Covenant & Constitutionalism* (Transaction).
- Recent reporting on Hormuz / Iran standoff (Times of Israel, ISW, JINSA updates August 2026).
- Israeli election calendar and polling (Times of Israel, Economist tracker, Jerusalem Post, August 2026).

Daily Learning Portions Master — Ki Tavo 6th Aliyah (15 Elul 5786)

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Copy-paste ready: Learned essay Daily Learning Portions — Friday, 15 Elul 5786 Erev Shabbat of Parshat Ki Tavo August 28, 2026 • ט"ו אלול תשפ"ו • Jerusalem / Israel

The King is in the field. The sixth aliyah of Ki Tavo is read on the threshold of Shabbat. Blessing and warning stand together in one covenant. Today's learning is not a private meditation only; it is a national accounting, a family table, and a preparation to receive Shabbat while Elul still holds the door open.

Today's Exact Daily Learning Portions

Secular date: Friday, August 28, 2026

Hebrew date (Israel): 15 Elul 5786 — ט"ו אלול תשפ"ו

Day character: Regular weekday that is Erev Shabbat, in the heart of Elul. Week of Parshat Ki Tavo. Shabbat begins this evening.

Chumash

Parshat Ki Tavo, 6th Portion

Devarim (Deuteronomy) 28:7-28:69

Chabad Chumash · Sefaria

Tehillim

Chapters 77-78

(Elul custom: the Baal Shem Tov's additional three chapters of Tehillim continue each day through Yom Kippur.)

Tehillim 77 · Tehillim 78

Tanya

Iggeret HaKodesh, beginning of Epistle 14

Tanya, IH 14 · Sefaria

Rambam / Sefer HaMitzvot

Daily Rambam cycle as listed on Chabad.org for the day (see the day's calendar page).

Daily Rambam

Hayom Yom

15 Elul — founding of Yeshivat Tomchei Temimim (15 Elul 5657 / 1897); beginning of studies in nigleh and Chassidus on 18 Elul; the name temimim proclaimed on Simchat Torah eve 5659.

Hayom Yom, Elul 15

Today in Jewish History

Tomchei Temimim founded (1897). The Yeshivah Tomchei Temimim Lubavitch — the first to integrate the revealed part of Torah (Talmud and Halachah) with the esoteric teachings of Chassidut in a formal study program — was founded on this date by the fifth Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Shalom DovBer Schneersohn (the Rebbe Rashab).

Elul and Erev Shabbat notes Daily shofar (weekday custom of Elul). Extra Tehillim chapters (Baal Shem Tov). Check tefillin and mezuzot. The Alter Rebbe's image: the King is in the field — accessible, smiling, receiving all who come. Candle lighting before sunset. Prepare early; leave time for Minchah, Kabbalat Shabbat, and a table that can hold both the day's learning and the children's questions.

Calendar source: Chabad.org day view

I. The Sixth Aliyah: When the Covenant Speaks in Two Registers

The sixth weekday portion of Ki Tavo does not let a Jew enter Shabbat on sentiment alone. It opens with blessing that is almost architectural:

“The Lord will cause your enemies who rise against you to be struck down before you; they shall come out against you one way and flee before you seven ways.” (Devarim 28:7)

The blessings of 28:1-14 — begun in the previous aliyot and completed here — describe a life in which rain, storehouse, womb, flock, city, and field all answer the same fidelity. Rashi, following the Sifrei, reads the opening condition of the chapter with unsentimental clarity: if you will listen — not once, but as a standing posture. Ibn Ezra stresses that the blessings are not magic; they are the natural fruit of a people whose inner order matches the covenant. Sforno hears in “the Lord will establish you as His holy people” the public consequence of private shemirat hamitzvot: holiness that can be seen.

Then the text turns.

From 28:15 the tochacha begins, and it does not hurry. Verse after verse maps the unraveling of the same structures the blessings had built: rain withheld, city and field cursed, confusion, fever, drought, defeat, exile of children, a heart that trembles at the sound of a driven leaf. The section runs to 28:68 and is sealed by 28:69:

“These are the words of the covenant which the Lord commanded Moshe to make with the children of Israel in the land of Moab, besides the covenant which He made with them at Horeb.”

Ramban, in his long comment on the tochacha, insists that these are not theatrical threats. They are the grammar of a relationship that takes history seriously. A covenant that cannot name consequence is not a covenant; it is a mood. Ohr HaChaim reads the density of the curses as a mercy disguised as severity: the Torah refuses to let a Jew pretend that distance from Hashem is costless. Kli Yakar notes how many of the afflictions strike communication and trust — the very bonds by which a people remains a people. Malbim distinguishes the inner collapse (a heart that does not know rest) from the outer collapse (siege, exile, sale). Abarbanel, ever the statesman, hears a warning to leadership: when the nation’s center forgets the covenant, the periphery cannot hold.

The sixth aliyah therefore places two facts on the same table, on the same Erev Shabbat:

Fidelity has a public shape. Blessing is not only inner peace; it is enemies fleeing seven ways, a storehouse that holds, children who remain. Infidelity also has a public shape. The Torah will not flatter. It will describe, in terrible patience, what happens when a holy people treats the covenant as optional.

This is Elul language. Not because Elul is grim, but because Elul is honest. The King is in the field precisely so that a Jew can come close before the books are opened. The tochacha is not the last word of Ki Tavo; the parsha will still speak of a covenant “which He commanded... besides the covenant at Horeb.” There is always another sealing. There is always a way back. But the way back is not denial. It is teshuvah that has looked the text in the face.

II. Tehillim 77-78: Memory as Avodah

Chapter 77 is Asaph in the night:

“I cry aloud to God, aloud to God that He may hear me... I remember God and I moan; I meditate, and my spirit faints.” (77:2-4)

The psalm does not begin with answers. It begins with a refusal to decorate distress. Then the turn: “I will remember the deeds of the Lord; yes, I will remember Your wonders of old.” The Red Sea, the unseen footprints, the shepherding of Yosef — memory becomes the instrument that pries the present open.

Chapter 78 is the long historical psalm. It is a father’s teaching and a nation’s confession in one breath:

“I will open my mouth in a parable; I will utter riddles from of old, which we have heard

and known, and our fathers have told us. We will not hide them from their children.” (78:2-4)

Then the record: Ephraim turning back in the day of battle, the fathers who tested God in the wilderness, the manna despised, the quail that became a plague, Shiloh abandoned, and still — “He, being merciful, atones for iniquity and does not destroy.” The psalm is Elul in lyric form. It refuses both amnesia and despair. A people that will not tell its children the truth about its failures cannot transmit the truth about its redemption.

On Erev Shabbat, these two chapters do a precise work. Chapter 77 gives language to the private cheshbon hanefesh that Elul demands. Chapter 78 gives language to the public mesorah that a Shabbat table must carry. A father who has read 78 before candle lighting knows that the stories told tonight are not entertainment. They are the mechanism by which the next generation does not become Ephraim turning back in the day of battle.

III. Tanya: Iggeret HaKodesh, Beginning of Epistle 14

The Alter Rebbe writes to arouse “the ancient love and the fondness for the Holy Land,” that it burn “like flashes of fire from the inwardness of man and from a deep heart,” as if this very day Hashem had placed a generous spirit upon the people — a spirit that gives, and gives more each year.

The letter turns on Devarim 11:12: “The eyes of the Lord your God are always upon it, from the beginning of the year to the end of the year.” Why “to the end of the year,” when the next year begins at that same instant? Because the light that sustains the Land — the efflux from Chochmah Ila’ah, the source of supernal life — is not a static beam. Each year the previous light withdraws (the night of Rosh Hashanah, when the moon is covered), and through shofar and prayer a new light descends, higher than any that has shone before. “From the beginning of the year to the end of the year” means: this year’s light has a term. Next year’s light is not a repeat. It is an elevation.

Therefore tzedakah for the Land, and love for the Land, must also rise year by year — “increase after increase... rising over the head, like the measure of kodesh ha’elyon.” The human gift is not a decoration on a finished world. It participates in the annual renewal of the light that founds the earth: “The Lord by wisdom founded the earth.”

Read on 15 Elul, two weeks and a day before Rosh Hashanah, the letter is not abstract metaphysics. It is an instruction for the remaining days of the field. The King is accessible now so that when the new light is drawn down, a Jew has already practiced the generosity and the love that match that light. Living in Jerusalem does not exempt a person from this letter; it intensifies it. The Land is not a backdrop. It is the place

upon which the eyes rest, and the place from which the new light must be answered.

IV. Hayom Yom and Today in Jewish History: Temimim

Hayom Yom for 15 Elul records three linked moments:

Sunday, 15 Elul 5657 (1897): founding of Yeshivat Tomchei Temimim. Wednesday, 18 Elul 5657: beginning of study in nigleh and Divrei Elokim Chayim. Simchat Torah eve 5659 (1898), after hakafot: the Rebbe Rashab proclaims the name of the yeshivah and the name of its students — temimim.

Later the Rashab would give the marching order: Kol hayotzei lemilchemet Beit David — whoever goes out to the war of the House of David. The House of David is the line of Mashiach. The war is not only against external enemies; it is the unrelenting work of making a whole Jew: revealed Torah and Chassidus in one curriculum, one person, one life.

The coincidence of calendar is not decorative. On the day the sixth aliyah of Ki Tavo places blessing and tochacha on the same page, the Rebbe Rashab founded a school whose entire method is integration. Nigleh without Chassidus can become dry law without inner life. Chassidus without nigleh can become mood without obligation. Temimut is the refusal of that split. A tamim is not naïve. He is whole.

For a father on Erev Shabbat in Elul, the history note is a chinuch document. What we found in 1897 we must find again at the table tonight: a child who hears both the tochacha and the love of the Land; a child who learns that memory (Tehillim 78) and new light (Tanya 14) belong to the same person.

V. Erev Shabbat in Elul: Ascent, Not Escape

Friday in Elul is a double threshold.

Elul says: the King is in the field; come now.

Erev Shabbat says: the field itself is about to become a sanctuary; prepare the house.

The two do not cancel. Shabbat does not pause teshuvah; it elevates it. The work of the six days — including the honest reading of Devarim 28 — is gathered, blessed, and made to rest. Practical preparation is therefore not a distraction from avodah. It is avodah:

Finish the weekday shofar before the holy day. Let the extra Tehillim of Elul be said with enough time that they are not swallowed by the rush to candles. Check that the house can receive Shabbat: food, lights, phones set down, a parsha word ready for children that does not flatten the tochacha into a scare-story and does not skip it as “too hard.” Remember the Alter Rebbe’s smiling King: the face we bring to the table is part of how the children will remember Elul.

The sixth aliyah is long and heavy. That is not a reason to hide it. It is a reason to frame it. Blessing first. Covenant as relationship. Consequence as the dignity of being taken seriously. Return as the open door that Elul exists to keep open.

VI. Avodah — Mind / Heart / Action / Speech / Time / Identity / Community

Mind. Learn the structure of Devarim 28 so that blessing and curse are not a blur. Know where 28:7 sits (completion of blessing) and where 28:15 begins (the tochacha). Read Rashi on the condition of listening, and Ramban on why a covenant must be able to name loss. Let Tanya 14 teach that “this year” is not last year repeated.

Heart. Tehillim 77 permits the moan. Do not skip it on the way to the “right” Elul feeling. Then let 77:12 work: remember the wonders. The heart that only inventories failure is not doing Elul; it is doing despair. The King in the field has a smiling face. Meet it.

Action. Increase one concrete kindness for the Land and for people in need — Tanya’s “increase after increase.” Check tefillin and mezuzot if not yet done this Elul. Prepare Shabbat earlier than comfort requires, so that Minchah and the first minutes of Shabbat are not stolen by unfinished weekday work.

Speech. Chapter 78 commands transmission. At the table, tell one piece of the day’s learning in language a child can carry: “Hashem takes us seriously. That is why there are blessings and warnings. And He still wants us close.” Avoid both flippancy and terror.

Time. 15 Elul is a midpoint marker. Rosh Hashanah is near enough to feel, far enough to work. Use the remaining weekdays of Elul as a measured ascent, not a panic. Shabbat tonight is not time off from that ascent; it is the form the ascent takes once a week.

Identity. Hayom Yom names the students temimim. The word is an aspiration: a Jew who does not split nigleh from nistar, blessing from responsibility, Pittsburgh grit from Jerusalem emunah, private teshuvah from public covenant.

Community. The tochacha is spoken to a people, not only to a soul. Ahavat Yisrael in Elul is not a slogan. It is the refusal to let another Jew face the field alone. Invite, share food, share a psalm, share a coin for the Land.

VII. Chinuch and the Shabbat Table

For a father of young children, the sixth aliyah is a test of craft.

Do not read the children a catalogue of curses. Read them the relationship. Hashem wants a people who listen. When we listen, life lines up — rain, food, safety, staying together. When we stop listening, life frays. That is not because Hashem is cruel. It is

because we matter.

Give them one image from Tanya: every year a new light. Shabbat is a weekly taste of new light. Rosh Hashanah will be a yearly gate of new light. Our job is to get ready with more kindness, not more fear.

Give them one image from Hayom Yom: a school that refused to split the revealed and the hidden. Tonight we will not split either. We will sing. We will eat. We will also remember that we are a people with a covenant.

Give them one line from Tehillim 78: we will not hide these things from our children. Then keep the promise by telling a true, short, hopeful story from the year that is ending.

If a child asks about the hard verses, answer without theater: “The Torah tells the truth about what happens when we leave Hashem. And then it keeps talking, because Hashem does not leave us.”

VIII. Covenantal Note — Only Where the Text Already Speaks

Devarim 28 is already a political theology. A people stands under a law it did not invent. Blessing is not the whim of a strongman; curse is not the revenge of a tyrant. Both are the public form of a higher law that limits every human power — including the power of the nation over itself. Limited authority, consequence, national responsibility, the refusal of domination that pretends to be above law: these are not imported slogans. They are the plain sense of a covenant made in Moab besides the covenant at Horeb.

Tanya 14 adds a further limit: even the year’s light has a term. Renewal is not automatic. It is drawn down. Human generosity participates. A republic of the covenant, if the phrase is used at all, would be a people that knows it is not sovereign in the final sense — and therefore can be trusted with limited, responsible power in the intermediate sense.

Do not force the comparison. Let the pesukim stand. They are enough.

IX. Toward Shabbat

Tonight the sixth aliyah will not be leined in shul as the Shabbat kariah; that belongs to tomorrow. But the weekday Jew who learned it this morning carries it into candle lighting. The King who was in the field all Elul is the same King for whom we now clear the table and light the flame.

Blessing and warning were read. Memory was recited. Love of the Land was aroused. A yeshivah of whole Jews was remembered at its founding. The work of Friday is to let all of that rest — not as forgotten, but as gathered.

Shabbat shalom.

Extended Bibliography Primary texts Deuteronomy 26–29 (Parshat Ki Tavo); especially 28:7–69. Sefaria Psalms 77–78. Sefaria Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi, Tanya, Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 14. Chabad Hayom Yom, Elul 15. Chabad Daily calendar: Chabad.org, 8/28/2026 Classical meforshim

Rashi, Ramban, Ibn Ezra, Sforno, Ohr HaChaim, Kli Yakar, Malbim, Abarbanel on Deuteronomy 28; Sifrei Devarim on the chapter's conditions.

Chassidus and Rebbe

Alter Rebbe on Elul ("the King is in the field"); Tanya IH 8 and 14; Rebbe Rashab on Tomchei Temimim and milchemet Beit David; the Rebbe's Hayom Yom; Baal Shem Tov extra Tehillim of Elul.